

LESSON 8

We have already looked at how words can be formed by looking at suffixes. In today's lesson we will look at some other ways, beginning with prefixes and stem words, followed by synonyms and antonyms as a means of enhancing your vocabulary.

A prefix is a letter or group of letters that is added to the beginning of a stem/ base word e.g in *untrue* the prefix is *un-* and the stem/base word is *true*. Words that are unfamiliar to you may sometimes consist of a stem word you know and an added prefix , for instance, We were shocked to learn of the *illimitability* of the dictator's power.

Illimitability is a word that does not often appear in print. It may be unfamiliar to you. However, you can locate its stem word, *limit*, which means 'to restrict'. If you also know that the prefix *il-* (as in *illegal*) means 'not', you should be able to determine that *illimitability* refers to that which has no limits or restriction. The sentence means ' we were shocked to learn that there is no limit to the dictator's power.

PREFIXES

NEGATIVE	SIZE	LOCATION	TIME AND ORDER	NUMBER
POSITIVE				
un-	semi-	inter-	pre-	mono-
non-	mini-	super-	ante-	bi-
in-	micro-	trans-	fore-	hex-
dis-		ex-	post-	oct-
re-		extra-		multi-
		mid-		

Study these tables and try to find additional examples. Use your dictionary if necessary.

Negative and positive prefixes

PREFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLES
un-		unmagnetized, in- not,
	unpunched	
im-	not good enough	incomplete
il-		impossible
ir-		illegal
		irregular, irrelevant
non-	not connected with	non-programmable, non-impact
mis-	bad, wrong	mispronounce
dis-	opposite feeling	disagree
	opposite action	disconnect
anti-	against	antisocial
de-	reduce, reverse	demagnetize, decode
under-	too little	underestimate

Positive prefixes

re- over-	do again too much	reorganize overheat
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Prefixes of Size

PREFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLES
semi-	half, partly	semiconductor
equi-	equal	equidistant
maxi-	big	maxicomputer
micro-	small	microcomputer
mini-	little	minicomputer
macro- mega-	large megabyte	macroeconomics

Prefixes of Location

PREFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLES
inter-	between, among	interface, interactive
super- trans-	over across	supersonic transmit, transfer
ex-	out	exclude, extrinsic
extra-	beyond	extraordinary
sub-	under	subschemata
infra-	below	infra-red
peri-	around	peripheral

Prefixes of Time and Order

PREFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLES
ante- pre-	before	antecedent prefix
prime-	first	primary, primitive
post-	after	postdated
retro-	backward	retroactive

Prefixes of Numbers

PREFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLES
semi-	half	semicircle
mono-	one	monochromatic
bi-	two	binary
tri-	three	triangle
quad-	four	quadruple
penta-	five	Pentagon
hex-	six	hexadecimal
septem-	seven	September
oct-	eight	octal
dec-	ten	decimal
multi-	many	multiprogramming, multiplexor

Other Prefixes

PREFIX	MEANING	EXAMPLES
pro-	for	program
auto-	self	automatic
co-	together	coordinate
neo-	new	neoclassical
pan-	all	Pan-Islamic

Having dealt with looking at the roots of words and how suffixes and prefixes work let us look at another way of enhancing your vocabulary:

Synonyms are words that have the same or nearly the same meaning. For example, big, large, huge, enormous, monumental, gigantic, immense, and colossal are synonyms. Synonyms have two characteristics that you must understand in order to use them appropriately.

First characteristic:

Most synonyms have similar meanings in only one of their senses. e.g. *appropriate* and *apt* are synonyms when they are used to indicate that something is 'fit' for a specific purpose.

He made an *appropriate* remark

He made an *apt* remark

Appropriate and *apt* may be used interchangeably to mean "fit" but they have other meanings that they do not share. For instance *apt* may mean "likely", but *appropriate* does not have this meaning.

When he is nervous he is *apt* to laugh.

Here *appropriate* may not be used interchangeably with *apt*.

Second Characteristic:

Synonyms often have shades of meaning in addition to the meaning they share.

For instance *blame* and *denounce* are synonyms that refer to the act of making an unfavourable judgement. However, to blame is to fix the responsibility for an error whereas to denounce is to state intense disapproval in public. If you receive a letter in your letterbox that should have been delivered to a neighbour, you may blame your postman, but you are not likely to publicly denounce the postal employee for such a trivial mistake.

On the other hand, if elected officials are found guilty of stealing taxpayers' money, they are denounced; they are severely criticised in public, and in some cases thrown out of office.

Blame does not convey the kind of unfavourable judgement that elected officials receive when they betray the trust of those who elected them.

Recap: We have dealt with Vocabulary Building in this lesson

by focussing on Affixes and Suffixes

